CINEMA ▼

MONKS WITH GUNS

SHENPENN KHYMSAR'S *4 RIVERS 6 RANGES* IS A HISTORICAL DRAMA ABOUT PEACEFUL TIBETANS TAKING UP ARMS TO SAVE THE DALAI LAMA



FIGHT THE POWER
Still from *4 Rivers 6 Ranges*

The first Tibetan feature in Indian theatres (released Sept. 18) is a white-knuckled historical drama in the vein of Quentin Tarantino's *Inglourious Basterds*, the alternate-history flick about American soldiers killing Hitler with a bomb. Except this story, by writer-director Shenpenn Khymsar in *4 Rivers 6 Ranges*, is true; a group of Tibetans did take up arms in 1958, fought the occupying Chinese army, and helped escort the 14th Dalai Lama to India.

In the film, this group, the 4 Rivers 6 Ranges, were peaceful Buddhists forced to kill the Chinese. Against them is a psychotic villain, General Tan, played by Robert Lin. The film is a distinctly mainstream take, different from Ritu Sarin and Tenzing Sonam's 1998 documentary, *The Shadow Circus: The CIA in Tibet*. Shot in 19 days on a Rs 6 crore budget, it had been Khymsar's passion project for 12 years. "Ten went into researching every book, PhD dissertation, the Nepal army's version, Tibetan version, Indian version, CIA's version," he says.

> THE FILM IS THE FIRST OF A TRILOGY AND WAS SHOT IN 19 DAYS, RESEARCHED OVER 12 YEARS THROUGH NARRATIVES OF MULTIPLE NATIONS

It's the first of a trilogy. "Chapter two is the CIA flying them to Camp Hale, Colorado, for training. Chapter three is on their demise," explains Khymsar. He hopes to raise funds for them and is hedging bets on the Hindi-language Indian release, backed by Hollywood's Richard Gere and Bollywood's Nawazuddin Siddiqui, who narrated it pro bono. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh



CHORE POLICE
Scene from Virasat and (inset) Anuradha Kapur

MUZAMIL BHAWANI

THEATRE ▶

Staging a Saga

KNMA presents *Virasat*, a hyper-realist staging of Marathi playwright Mahesh Elkunchwar's Wada trilogy, directed by Anuradha Kapur

Condensing Mahesh Elkunchwar's Wada trilogy, written across two decades and generally staged as three plays, into a single evening was never going to be effortless. But, for theatre director Anuradha Kapur, former director of National School of Drama, the challenge lay less in cutting text than in preserving rhythm. "A hyper-realist score is primarily defined by material," she insists.

Get set to witness water, cooking, cleaning, swabbing just two feet away from you. For Kapur, *Virasat*, presented by KNMA, is about mapping the everyday rudiments—how ordinary chores, farming for men, housekeeping for women, become both a means of survival and a form of quiet confinement, especially for women who enter the house and often leave only at death.

The preoccupation with landscape drew her to Sunder Nursery in Delhi. Insisting that it is not merely a garden, but a landscape, echoing the way the wadas of Elkunchwar's plays were woven into their surroundings. Staging theatre outdoors, she opines, is an invitation to let the site intervene in the work.

Scenographer Deepan Sivaraman, her collaborator of over a decade, built on ideas first tested at Black Box Okhla, a "house within a black box", bringing audiences within two or three feet of the action. That proximity forces the viewer to ask—are you a relative, a neighbour, a bystander looking at the family from behind the kitchen or the patriarch's bed?

The play, Kapur stresses, "remains contemporary as it charts feudal collapse, rural standstill and the hushed erosion of landscape itself." ■

—Sukant Deepak



ADITEE BISWAS

Virasat will be staged at Sunder Nursery in Delhi from **Sept. 24 to 27 at 7 pm**